decorating small village churches across the Slovenian ethnic territory in what was then Fascist Italy. His frescos skilfully depict disguised versions of Mussolini and other Fascist frontmen, wearing the robes of Pontius Pilate and other figures complicit in Jesus' death.

In 1941, Fascist Italy made another move eastwards and occupied most of Slovenia. At home, my father's family supported the (Communist-led) resistance movement during World War II without knowing much about the Communist agenda behind it; for Slovenians in the Italian-occupied areas, national liberation and the fight against Fascism took precedence over any other consideration. Even so, after the war, the family was put under surveillance because of its Catholic connections. My father left teaching because of the pressure and went on to become a dentist.

My mother's family ran a relatively large farm in central Slovenia, near what was then the border between Yugoslavia and the Italian kingdom. During World War II, this family also largely supported the resistance movement led by the Communists but some of the extended family joined the anti-Communist forces too. Two of her uncles lost their lives in the post-war massacres. After the war, despite their support for the resistance, large areas of the family estate were confiscated.

Politics was often discussed in our home but we soon learnt to live double lives. In school, we had to join in the praises of the resistance movement, the Communist Party and Tito. Religion, let alone politics, could not be discussed at all – even the word Christmas could not be mentioned.

Of course, not everyone in Slovenia (or, for that matter, in other Eastern European countries) felt the same way about the Communist system as my family did. As well as those who were obviously corrupt, there were many people who, because of family tradition or for other reasons, sincerely believed in the system. Among the Party members there were some genuinely honest people. Some individuals among them, though few, even revolted and paid the price. And then there were the kinds of pragmatic individuals that are found in every society, who simply adapt to the situation, never raise their heads above the parapet, never speak up and just want to get by. It is important to realise this in order to understand that the return to democracy in the 1990s was not greeted with equal enthusiasm by all strata of society. I am not just speaking here of Party apparatchiks but also of a number of people who simply got used to the system and were not